

Pat Haggerty Rules WAC Kingdom

By MIKE SOWELL
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When Pat Haggerty makes a legal ruling, there is no court of appeals to back him up. As many as 23,000 people may object to his verdicts and there are no bailiffs to help him maintain order in the court.

Haggerty is a Western Athletic

Conference basketball official and for the past 22 years he has been a traveling lawman in the western United States, holding court in such places as Bozeman, Mont. and Albuquerque, N.M.

His word is law but he isn't always afforded the respect that goes with his peers in the legal profession.

"You instill in your mind that you're like a judge," says Haggerty. "You've got to see both sides of the question and give a fair interpretation. A guy finds out real soon if he can't take the abuse people give him. It gets to the point when you don't pay any attention to it. You can't."

"I've been hit with oranges, bananas, fried chicken, even snow balls. You just throw them off the court and keep going. I've been hit by coins, too. You put the coins in your pocket."

It wasn't the chance to pick up some spare change that attracted Haggerty to officiating. A former professional baseball player who played for El Paso's Andy Cohen at Denver in the early 1950s, Haggerty enjoys the opportunity to stay involved in athletics.

He also is an official for the National Football League and he has seen more than his share of cheap hotels and airport terminals.

"That's the hardest part, the travel," Haggerty says. "Not knowing whether you'll get there or not because of the weather. Officiating is an avocation rather than a vocation. You have other responsibilities which must come first."

"I can't tell you how much time I've spent traveling but I kept track of the mileage one year. It was 75,000 miles in one year for football and basketball."

One of the whistlestops on Haggerty's schedule this year was El Paso, where he and John Overby were to work the UTEP-Arizona State game in Memorial Gym last week.

Haggerty and Overby were expected to have their work cut out for them on this night. The 5,000 fans which will pack the gym are among the more volatile in the league and opposing coaches Ned Wulk and Don Haskins are well-known for their ability to cross-exam officials during the course of play.

"The majority of the coaches are (Please Turn To Page 6B)



OH YEAH — Two vocal Miner fans let the officials know how they feel about a call. And in a place like

Memorial Gym, their opinions could be heard clearly by the officials on the floor.

—(Times Photo by Lance Murray)